

So you're thinking about accounting

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-eight careers on how exposed they are to AI.

A licensed CPA doing audit and advisory: **5.2** out of 10.

Bookkeeping and transactional accounting: **7.9**.

Same profession. The licence is doing nearly all of the work.

The 60-second version

- The licensed end holds up. The tier below it isn't really a career any more.
 - Bookkeeping was already at 6.8 back in 2023 — before generative AI existed.
 - There's a severe shortage: **120,000+ openings a year against about 55,000 graduates**.
 - 43 states have changed the rules to make qualifying faster and cheaper. That's new.
 - The honest weakness is the starting salary, and it's a real gap.
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The thing that just changed

Start here, because it's the most useful thing in this document and it's about a year old.

For forty years, becoming a CPA required **150 credit hours** — basically a fifth year of university. It cost an extra year of tuition plus a year of not earning, and it became the single biggest reason people picked finance or tech instead.

The profession noticed. Enrolments fell for over a decade. CPA exam numbers hit their lowest since 2006. Around 300,000 accountants left in five years.

So they changed it. Roughly **43 states** have now altered or scrapped the 150-hour rule. The common new route is a normal bachelor's degree plus two years of supervised experience, instead of a fifth year of study.

A profession deliberately making it easier to get in, while most professions are making it harder, is genuinely unusual.

Practical instruction: check the current rules wherever you'd actually qualify. Anything your school or a careers site told you before 2025 is probably out of date.

Why the licensed end is protected

Only a licensed CPA can sign an audit opinion. Not review it, not supervise it — sign it, with personal liability attached. Liability is a legal thing, not a technical thing. No amount of capability transfers it.

And here's the part that matters more for you. The CPA pathway also requires supervised experience hours — which means firms have to keep hiring and training juniors, even where the work could be automated.

Compare law. A bar card protects the courtroom and the signature. It says nothing about who reads forty thousand documents, so that work went — and junior law now scores 7.9.

So when you look at any career with a licence, ask what it actually reserves — and whether it reserves the training too. That second one matters far more when you're the one trying to get in.

The scores

TRACK	SCORE
Audit / CPA advisory	5.2
Tax advisory (complex)	5.6
Management accounting / controller	6.3
Routine tax preparation	7.0
Bookkeeping / transactional	7.9

The pattern: the closer you are to signing something you're answerable for, the safer you are.

What already happened, and what it tells you

Most careers in this index show a sharp change after 2023. Accounting doesn't — because its bottom tier was automated years earlier.

Data entry, reconciliation, categorisation: these were among the very first white-collar tasks to go, and that was mature before generative AI arrived.

So accounting is the closest thing we have to seeing what "finished" looks like. Not collapse — a tier that quietly stopped being a career while the profession above it carried on.

The shortage, and the trap in reading it

The numbers are real:

- **120,000+ annual openings** projected by BLS, against roughly **55,000 graduates**
- Around **190,000–200,000 open positions** at any time
- **300,000 accountants left in five years**, and those remaining skew late-career
- Starting salaries rising in response

But here's the trap. The shortage is severe and the entry tier is automating, at the same time. Both are true, because they're happening at different levels. The profession badly needs licensed CPAs and barely needs bookkeepers.

If you read "accounting shortage" as a general green light, you've misread it. It's a green light for the licensed path specifically.

What we won't soften

The starting salary gap is the profession's real problem.

- First-year audit associate: **\$55,000–\$70,000**
- First-year financial analyst: **\$75,000–\$95,000**
- First-year software engineer: **\$90,000–\$130,000**

Same students. Same universities. And the gap has widened every single year.

That is the honest reason people pick finance or tech instead, and no amount of talking about job security makes those numbers different.

Busy season is real too. January to April in tax and audit is genuinely punishing, every year, and it's the most-cited reason people leave for industry.

What you get in exchange: a licence, a severe shortage, and a door that's currently getting wider. Whether that trade is worth it is a real question, not a rhetorical one.

Does this actually sound like you?

Accounting suits people who:

- Are **comfortable in detail** — not tolerant of it, comfortable in it. Different things.
- Like **understanding how businesses actually work** from the inside
- Are **sceptical by nature**. Professional scepticism — not taking things at face value — is the core skill, and it's closer to temperament than training.
- Want a **clear qualification and a marked path**, which accounting gives you better than almost any other business route

Harder if you want high early earnings, need variety over rhythm, or find detail draining rather than absorbing.

The skill nobody's teaching yet

Audit is changing more than the score suggests, and in a way that's actually more interesting.

It used to mean testing a *sample*. Now you can test the *whole population* automatically — which means the job becomes investigating the exceptions the system flagged, rather than checking a selection by hand.

That's a better job. It's also a different skill from the one accountancy training has historically built.

And the thing to protect: accountants used to learn a client's business by building its numbers. That was boring and it was the education. Now it's automated, so understanding the business has to be pursued deliberately — and that understanding is what separates someone who can sign from someone who can only prepare.

What actually matters when picking a course

- Does it map to the **current CPA requirements** where you'd qualify? Ask directly — this has changed.
- **Internship placement and conversion rate**. The profession recruits through internships, and the shortage means access is easier than it's been in years.
- **How much compulsory audit and assurance content?** That's where the protection lives. A course light on audit is training you for the exposed tier.

- Do they teach data analytics and audit technology?
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Two things worth doing

Get an internship. Firms are short-staffed and recruiting hard, so this is more accessible right now than it has been in a long time. It's also how most people get hired.

Then find someone three to five years into public practice and ask what they actually did in year one — and whether that work still exists in the same form.

One route note

Go into public practice first, then industry if you want. The reverse rarely works, and public practice is where the supervised hours and the licence come from.

That's the single most common mistake people make with this career.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- **Accountants and auditors — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — the government's own data on openings, pay and requirements.
 - **120 vs 150: the new CPA licensure pathways** — read this one. It's the practical version of the rule change, and it directly affects how you'd qualify.
 - **Removing the 150-hour hurdle** — why the profession changed its own entry requirements, and which states have moved.
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There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the honest downsides, what to ask a program, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.